Wegener’s theory was not well received at first. In 1943, George Gaylord Simpson, one of the most influential paleontologists in the US, criticized the theory. He argued that the fossil record could be explained by static continents linked and unlinked by periodic flooding.



This fossilized head of the extinct reptile *Cynognathus crateronotus* was found in southern Africa. The same fossils occur in South America: evidence that the two continents were once one.

Evidence and evolution

Despite early doubts, evidence for the plate tectonics theory grew. A series of discoveries established that the seafloor was spreading and that new oceanic crust was constantly being created. We now understand that the movement of the tectonic plates is driven by convection currents carrying heat from deep inside the planet to the surface.